

The start from scratch approach

We have all gotten our beliefs about the world from a variety of sources. Some are based on serious thought and investigation. Some are based on what our parents told us. Some are based on what our friends told us. Some are probably based on nothing at all. If we want to really figure out what we should and should not believe, we need to avoid taking anything for granted. Instead, we should assume nothing, and test all of our beliefs against some standard to see which ones we should keep, and which ones we should get rid of.

The natural next question is: what is the standard by which we should decide which of our beliefs to keep, and which to discard?

Here again Descartes gives us an answer.

“Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my assent from opinions which are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I do from those which are patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinions, it will be enough if I find in each of them some reason for doubt.”

Here's an example. Suppose that I introduce you to my dog, which is a small black and white dog with curly hair. Suppose you form the belief that my dog is a poodle.

But now suppose that you find out that there are small black and white dogs with curly hair which are not poodles. In particular, Havanese dogs are quite popular in the area, and are also of that size with those markings.

It looks like you would now have found a reason for doubting your initial belief.

No Good Argument $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you can't prove P, don't
believe P.

What would it mean for you to find in someone belief a reason for doubt?



The start from scratch approach

We have all gotten our beliefs about the world from a variety of sources. Some are based on serious thought and investigation. Some are based on what our parents told us. Some are based on what our friends told us. Some are probably based on nothing at all. If we want to really figure out what we should and should not believe, we need to avoid taking anything for granted. Instead, we should assume nothing, and test all of our beliefs against some standard to see which ones we should keep, and which ones we should get rid of.

which to keep, and which to discard?

The natural next question is: what is the standard by which we should decide



‘Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my assent from opinions which are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I do from those which are patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinions, it will be enough if I find in each of them some reason for doubt.’



small black and white dog with curly hair. Support for the belief

that my dog is a poodle.

Here's an example. Suppose that I introduce you to my dog, which is a



dogs with curly hair which are not poodles. In particular, Havana dogs

are quite popular in the area, and are also of that size with the

But now suppose that you find out that there are small black and white

markings.

berief.

It looks like you would not have found a reason for doubting your initial



If you can't prove P , don't

de l'œuvre.

No Good Argument $\rightarrow$ No Belief













































































































‘Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my assent from opinions which are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I do from those which are patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinions, it will be enough if I find in each of them some reason for doubt.’

small black and white dog with curly hair. Support the belief

that my dog is a poodle.

Here's an example. Suppose that I introduce you to my dog, which is a

dogs with curly hair which are not poodles. In particular, Havanese dogs

are quite popular in the area, and are also of that size with the se

But now suppose that you find out that there are small black and white

markings.

beief.

It looks like you would not have found a reason for doubting your initial











































































































